THE SHE LIST
UNDER 50

THE **SPORTSWOMEN**

A Heavyweight Legacy

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

An Olympic silver medallist and world champion, Mirabai Chanu has carried Indian weightlifting for nearly a decade. Her 2026 CWG gold, as well as three national records, show that she continues to raise the benchmark

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

Five months of complete bed rest nearly ended Mirabai Chanu's weightlifting career. A serious back injury after the 2018 Commonwealth Games left her unable to even get out of bed. "Lying in bed, I often wondered how I'd ever lift weights again," she says. "At that point, I thought I would have to quit weightlifting."

The comeback that followed has become a part of Chanu's legacy. She claimed India's first Olympic silver in weightlifting at the 2020 Tokyo Games, adding to a career that included a World Championship gold and Commonwealth Games success. This year, she reaffirmed her place among the country's finest athletes, winning another CWG gold and setting three national records at the National Weightlifting Championships.

For Chanu, success has always been rooted in conviction, with her mother remaining her greatest source of strength. "She has supported me from the very beginning," she says. "She knows everything I have been through, from injuries to all the struggles."

As one of India's most recognisable sporting icons, representing the Northeast has been deeply personal. "I wanted to show people what my identity represents. I belong to Manipur and to the Northeast," she says. Her message to young women is shaped by experience. "There is nothing we cannot achieve," she says. "But if we want to compete at the world level, three things are essential: hard work, sacrifice and discipline." ■

— Hrijoy Das Kanungo

HER MOTIVATION

"I always wanted to be in sports. The moment I joined the national camp, I knew I had to do something big. From then on, I realised this was the field I wanted to dedicate my life to. I believed that if I worked harder and stayed committed, I could achieve something for India. That was the real turning point for me"